

**TUNISIA****Capital city:** Tunis**Area:** 63,169 sq miles
(163,610 sq km)**Population:** 9,800,000**Official language:** Arabic**Major religions:** Muslim
98%, Christian 1%,
Jewish 1%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Tunisian dinar**Adult literacy rate:** 73%**Life expectancy:** 73 years**People per doctor:** 1,429**Televisions:** 334 per 1,000
people

TUNISIA

NORTHWESTERN AFRICA'S SMALLEST country, Tunisia lies between Libya to the south and Algeria to the west. Throughout its history, Tunisia has had close links with Europe. It was at the heart of the ancient empire of Carthage in the 4th century BC, and later became part of the mighty Roman Empire. In the 7th century, Tunisia was colonized by Muslim Arabs, and in the early 1880s by French forces. It became independent in 1956. The government has since been restructured and a multi party system introduced.

TUNISIAN FOOD

Traditional food is influenced by Arabic, Turkish, and French cooking. The national dish is couscous, a mix of semolina, meat, and vegetables. Spicy stews cooked in clay pots, called *tajines*, are also popular. For dessert, people eat fruit, dates stuffed with almond paste, or *baklava*, a sweet nut and honey pastry. To drink, there is strong black coffee or mint tea. Many Tunisian men go to cafés in the evening to meet friends and drink coffee.



A heap of steamed
couscous served
with roast chicken
and sausages



A glass of strong,
sweet mint tea



Brightly dyed wool
will soon be woven
into carpets.

INDUSTRY

Until the collapse of world oil prices in the 1980s, Tunisia's major exports were oil and gas. Today, textiles and agricultural products have become much more important. Tunisia is also one of the world's leading producers of calcium phosphates, used to make chemicals and fertilizers. Most of the country's industries are located in and around the capital city, Tunis.

TOURISM

Tunisia's warm winter climate and historic sites attract numerous tourists each year. Until 1976, tourism was Tunisia's highest earner of foreign currency. Numbers fell in the early 1980s, but have now risen again to more than 5 million tourists per year. The government has encouraged the building of new hotels and the development of resorts to meet the growing demand. Hundreds of thousands of Tunisians work in the tourist industry.



Libya: 25%



Germany: 12%



France: 17%



Algeria: 14%



Other: 32%

Most tourists come from neighboring Algeria and Libya, and from Europe. Cheaper air travel and the search for an exotic vacation location have made Tunisia a favorite destination for Europeans.



Grapes grow
well in Tunisia's
light soil and
strong sunshine.



Oranges and
limes come from
groves along the
fertile coast.



Dates are grown in
the desert oases
in the dry south.

AGRICULTURE

About two-thirds of Tunisia is suitable for farming. Many areas suffer from a lack of rainfall and rely on irrigation to water crops. The main crops include cereals, such as wheat and barley, citrus fruits, grapes, figs, dates, and olives. Tunisia is the world's fourth largest producer of olive oil. Despite efforts to improve output, however, Tunisia still has to import many basic foods.

**ARTS AND CRAFTS**

One of the liveliest parts of a Tunisian city is the *souk*, or market. The *souk* is a maze of narrow, winding streets, each crowded with traders and craftsmen selling their wares. Here, you can buy a wide range of traditional arts and crafts, including copper pots and pans, carpets, leather goods, jewelry, and embroidered cloth. Other stalls sell fish, meat, fruit, and vegetables.

Find out more

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